2010, while Menon and Chidambaram, both conciliators, took charge of India's security and foreign policy. In February 2010, hardly a month after Narayanan's exit, top US diplomats expressed hope that India's Kashmir policy had 'become consolidated under the more forward leaning Home Minister P.C. Chidambaram after the exit of National Security Advisor M.K. Narayanan, who played a dominant, conservative and often obstructive role in GOI policy on Kashmir'.[79] Under the new setup, the powers of the NSA were diluted with Chidambaram responsible for all issues related to domestic and foreign intelligence.[80] This meant that India was entering a phase of constructive engagement with Pakistan and Kashmiri separatists that would bode well for the region as well as the reconciliation process in Afghanistan. New Delhi had accepted 'reintegration' of mid-level Taliban fighters and commanders in mainstream Afghan social and political life. Menon and Chidambaram made sure that India did not lag behind, and orchestrated a pragmatic pro-reconciliation policy shift soon after the London conference. Aware of its limitation of going alone in Afghanistan, this shift was in keeping with India's multi-stakeholder strategy in Afghanistan.

Secondly, there was a clash between India's desire to be seen as a responsible international player in Afghanistan and its intent to strike a balance between Afghanistan and Pakistan. Menon and Chidambaram's conciliatory shift did not mean that India endorsed the London conference. There was a key conceptual difference between India's approach towards reconciliation from the one advocated by London. New Delhi accepted the reconciliation to occur on Kabul's terms and not those set by the Taliban or Pakistan. For this, it was imperative to frontload preconditions for the talks to commence. One such condition included accepting the 2004 Afghan constitution by the Taliban. Setting precondition was not possible according to British policymakers. Accepting the Afghan constitution could only be an 'outcome' of talks, London argued.[81] Then Foreign Secretary David Miliband and British ambassador to Kabul, Sherard Cowper-Coles, advocated the latter perspective forcefully among Western policy circles.[82] India's differences with the British (in particular) were so strong that Holbrooke had to clarify to Narayanan days before the conference that Cowper-Coles' thinking on the issue of talking to the Taliban did not reflect US policy.[83] Distinguishing between reconciliation and reintegration, Holbrooke reasserted